

The pills called PDE5 inhibitors treat **erectile dysfunction (ED)**. One of them, tadalafil, also eases the urinary symptoms of an **enlarged prostate**. The four are **sildenafil (Viagra)**, **tadalafil (Cialis)**, **ildenafil and avanafil**. They help your body make an erection when you are aroused. They do not cause one on their own.

How It Works

These medicines **relax the blood vessels** in the penis so blood can flow in. They work **only with sexual arousal**. Tadalafil also relaxes muscle in the prostate and bladder, so a low daily dose can ease urinary symptoms a little.

What to Expect

- **Sildenafil and vardenafil** are taken about an hour before sex. **Avanafil** can work in as little as 15–30 minutes.
- **Tadalafil** lasts longer, up to about 36 hours. It can also be taken as a **low dose every day**.
- A large or fatty meal can **delay** sildenafil and vardenafil. Tadalafil and avanafil are not much affected by food.
- No one pill works best for everyone. You and your team choose by timing, cost and side effects.
- Using the pill the right way matters. If it does not work, try it several more times, and ask your team about your dose, before deciding it has failed.

Learn the Terms

PDE5 inhibitor

The group of pills, such as sildenafil and tadalafil, used for ED.

Erectile dysfunction (ED)

Trouble getting or keeping an erection firm enough for sex.

Nitrates

Heart and chest-pain medicines that must never be taken with these pills.

As-needed or daily

Taken before sex, or a low dose every day.

BPH

An enlarged prostate. Tadalafil also treats its urinary symptoms.

Priapism

An erection that lasts 4 hours or more. It is an emergency.

The rule that matters most: Never take these pills with **nitrates** (such as nitroglycerin or isosorbide for chest pain), with “poppers” (amyl nitrite), or with riociguat. Together they can cause a **dangerous drop in blood pressure**. Tell every doctor and nurse that you take a PDE5 inhibitor.

How to Take It

- Take it **as prescribed**: before sex, or every day.
- Take no more than one dose in 24 hours.
- Do not add a second ED pill, such as sildenafil on top of daily tadalafil, on your own.

Important Safety

- If you take an **alpha blocker** for the prostate or other blood pressure medicines, you may get dizzy. Your team may start you on a lower dose.
- If you have **heart disease**, check with your doctor that sex and these pills are safe for you.
- Heavy drinking adds to dizziness.
- Tell your team about kidney or liver disease, eye disease, and all your medicines. Some, such as the HIV medicine ritonavir, change your dose.

Common Side Effects

- Headache, **flushing**, stuffy nose, indigestion
- Back or muscle aches, mostly with tadalafil
- A short-lived change in color vision with sildenafil

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Side effects that bother you
- A pill that does not work after several tries

Go to an emergency department if:

- An erection lasts **4 hours** or more, even if it does not hurt
- You suddenly lose vision or hearing. Stop the pill.
- You have chest pain or faint. Tell the staff which pill you took and when.
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. These pills help you get an erection when you are aroused. They do not work on their own.
2. **Never take them with nitrates or poppers.**
3. Give the pill a fair trial, used the right way, before deciding it does not work.